can override, provide ways to extend the core functionality, and are generally easier to use in your applications.

Ecto is an example of an extensible library that sits at the highest level of abstraction. It sits on top of Postgrex for socket protocol and DBConnection for connection pooling.

The Major Players

Let's look at a few of the major HTTP client libraries. You'll see these names in the Elixir community, so it's important to know what they are and the different roles they fill.

The history of HTTP clients in Elixir actually starts with a familiar face: Erlang. Let's look at the clients:

:httpc

Erlang ships with an included HTTP client module called :httpc. It only supports HTTP/1.1 protocol—not HTTP/2—and is a bit cumbersome to use. The options needed to properly make SSL requests, for example, are complex to remember and use.

Because of its relative difficulty, :httpc isn't commonly used. You'll see it used by some low-level libraries that don't want to include an HTTP library dependency, but very rarely.

Hackney and HTTPoison

The hackney[2] library is an all-included library that lets you make HTTP requests in Erlang. This isn't commonly used directly in Elixir. Instead, HTTPoison[3] wraps it and provides a friendly interface.

In the past, there were some problems with Hackney's security defaults (particularly around SSL) that caused people to move away from it. Despite this, you'll see HTTPoison commonly used even today.

Mint

Mint[4] is a socket protocol library for HTTP/1 and HTTP/2. It was written by members of the Elixir core team (but it isn't maintained by the core team) to solve shortcomings with the existing low-level HTTP clients at the time. It provides a better foundation for higher-abstraction HTTP clients than :httpc does.

2. https://github.com/benoitc/hackney
3. https://github.com/edgurgel/httpoison
4. https://github.com/elixir-mint/mint